BOOKS

CONTAINING MULTITUDES



SIDDHARTHA DEB's *The Light at the End of the World* is a saga of continental proportions that travels effortlessly through time

Siddhartha Deb's *The Light at the End of the World* tells the story of modern India through multiple, intersecting timelines. The story moves between present-day Delhi, 1984 on the eve of the Bhopal Disaster, 1947 Calcutta on the cusp of Indian Independence, 1859 and the immediate aftermath of the Revolt, and back again to the present day. In each timeline, individuals are caught up in the great currents of the age, currents characterised by violence—whether it is the violence of the coloniser, the genocidal violence of Partition, or the industrial violence of the oleum gas leak. Their stories, connected by thin threads of history, constitute an ensemble where different characters speak in different registers.

In doing so, *The Light at the End of the World* draws on multiple traditions and conventions of narrative. The most obvious one is the use of an inter-generational frame to unspool what is, in essence, a national history (with a fair bit of scepticism about nations and how they are constituted). Gabriel Garcia Marquez's *One Hundred Years of Solitude* (1967) is, of course, a predecessor, but Jennifer Makumbi's *Kintu* (2014)—which does something similar for Uganda—is perhaps a more appropriate point of comparison, given overlapping colonial and post-colonial histories.

A more striking effect that the book achieves, however, is a simultaneous nearness and distancing from its subject matter. We see this most recently in NoViolet Bulawayo's *Glory* (2022), a story of post-colonial Zimbabwe. Like Bulawayo, Deb's historical moments are drawn from actual history, and the characters who appear on stage come from the pages of history. Simultaneously, however, Deb distances the reader from the immediacy of the historical retelling by interposing evidently fictional narrators, thus creating a fictional frame of

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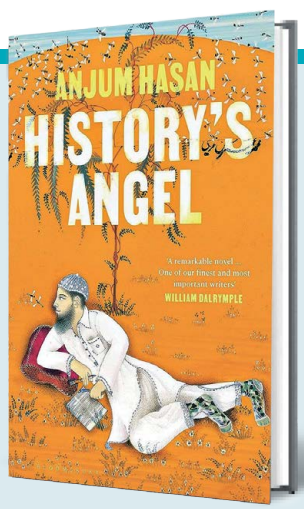
History and its Discontents

Anjum Hasan's novel ***History's Angel*** tells a story that is deeply relevant for our times

Alif is one of the most important characters in contemporary literature. His mind is a screen on which history plays out and the future makes suggestions, his thoughts providing the commentary. *History's Angel* is much like him—intelligent, subtle, reflective, gentle, sensitive.

Alif teaches history in a school, focusing not on dates and rulers but on continuities and inevitabilities. He takes students out to Delhi's monuments and we soon glimpse trouble. At Humayun's tomb, a student insults the teacher and also insists on mixing up the Mughal emperor with Hanuman.

Alif is Arabic for 'kind, compassionate'; yet, it is the one moment of madness when he twists the ear of that student, Ankit (meaning 'naughty'), which leads to his downward spiral. History, which was a refuge from reality, suddenly becomes reality itself. This ordinary man's refusal to part with common sense either in school or at home makes him



HISTORY'S ANGEL
By Anjum Hasan
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